STRAT OPS

METROPOLITAN WASHINGTON AIRPORTS AUTHORITY

Office of Strategy and Operational Performance

From Compliance to Capability: A Strategic Review of the MWAA Contracting Manual

An Analytical Report Generated by the AI Research Council

Transform Airports — AI Research Council

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FINAL — FOR DISTRIBUTION

Prompt Used

Your assignment is to conduct a comprehensive strategic assessment of the current MWAA Contracting Manual (in /sources) and develop a prioritized modernization roadmap.

Begin by thoroughly reviewing the Contracting Manual to understand its policies, procedures, governance framework, approval structures, risk controls, procurement methods, delegated authorities, competition requirements, contract administration practices, and underlying operating philosophy. Do not limit your analysis to compliance or procedural correctness. Instead, critically evaluate whether the manual enables MWAA to operate as a high-performing, innovation-oriented, infrastructure-focused public authority capable of delivering major capital projects, operational improvements, technology initiatives, and strategic partnerships efficiently and responsibly.

Conduct independent research into current best practices from leading airport authorities, transportation agencies, public infrastructure organizations, federal and state procurement programs, public-private partnership frameworks, progressive procurement models, and emerging procurement innovations. Compare MWAA's approach against recognized leaders in public-sector procurement and infrastructure delivery. Identify outdated provisions, unnecessary bureaucracy, process bottlenecks, risk-averse structures that create limited value, missed opportunities for innovation, and areas where modern procurement strategies could improve speed, transparency, competition, value creation, supplier engagement, or project outcomes.

Develop a portfolio of recommendations ranging from incremental improvements to transformational reforms. For each recommendation, provide: (1) a concise description; (2) the underlying problem being solved; (3) expected benefits; (4) implementation considerations; (5) examples of comparable organizations using similar approaches; and (6) a score from 1–10 in each of the following categories: Potential Impact, Implementation Effort (lower effort scores indicate easier implementation), and Strategic Innovation (the degree to which the recommendation represents leading-edge procurement practice). Calculate an overall priority ranking that favors high-impact, low-effort recommendations while separately highlighting a category of "Moonshot Reforms" representing frontier procurement strategies that could position MWAA as a national leader.

The final report should include an executive summary, key findings, benchmark observations, a ranked recommendations matrix, quick wins, medium-term reforms, large transformational opportunities, and a concluding vision describing what a best-in-class airport authority procurement system could look like. The report examines this claim across the following: Review and analysis of the existing MWAA Contracting Manual; Assessment of procurement policies, procedures, governance, and authorities; Evaluation of procurement methods and sourcing strategies; Review of approval workflows and decision-making structures; Assessment of competition requirements and vendor engagement practices.

How This Report Was Produced

This report is the product of the Transform Airports AI Research Council — a multi-agent analytical system running on Anthropic's Claude models. Rather than a single model writing in one pass, the Council convenes a panel of specialized research agents, subjects their work to adversarial review, and verifies every claim before publication. The process runs in four stages, with human review at two checkpoints.

Stage 1 — Independent research. Each research agent below produced an evidence brief without seeing the others' work, so the analysis draws on genuinely independent lines of evidence rather than a single line of reasoning.

Stage 2 — Synthesis and adversarial review. A Strategist synthesized the briefs into an argument; a Red Team attacked it across two rounds; the Strategist revised after each.

Stage 3 — Edit and fact-check. An Editor tightened the prose. A Fact-checker verified every number against the research briefs, removing or flagging what it could not source.

Stage 4 — Production. The verified draft was formatted into this document.

Research agents seated for this report

- Airport CEO
- Airport COO
- Airport Procurement Expert
- Chief Engineer
- Deep Research (o3)
- Operations Analyst
- Regulatory & Political Analyst
- The Slacker
- Technology Scout
- Virtual Chris

Process agents (on every report)

- **Strategist —** synthesized the research briefs into a single argumentative draft.
- **Red Team —** attacked each draft to surface weak claims and logical gaps.
- **Editor —** tightened the prose and removed filler without adding new content.
- **Humanizer —** refined tone and readability without altering any claim, number, or citation.
- **Fact-checker —** verified every numerical and attributed claim against the briefs, after all editorial passes.

Each agent is governed by a versioned specification — its analytical mandate, evidentiary standards, source discipline, and argumentative posture. The complete technical definitions for every agent on the Council are published and openly available at:
https://github.com/TransformAirports/ai-council/tree/main/.claude/agents

From Compliance to Capability: A Strategic Review of the MWAA Contracting Manual

Transform Airports AI Council — Stage 3 final fact-checked draft

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I. The clock the manual forgot to keep

On August 25, 2025, the Metropolitan Washington Airports Authority issued a request for proposals for work worth about $4.9 million. Bids closed December 10. The contract was awarded May 22, 2026 — nine months after the solicitation hit the street, more than five months after the last proposal landed [Source: deep-research-brief]. At $4.9 million this was an ordinary proposal-based buy, not a major capital action on new ground — a nine-month round trip too short to have carried a multi-year environmental review or federal grant concurrence. What stood between requirement and award was the Authority's own process — the Contracting Manual, Sixth Edition 6.0, effective May 20, 2026, roughly 130 pages of it. The manual does not contain a single sentence saying how long an award is supposed to take.

That one procurement is not, by itself, an indictment. But it is not an outlier either. In April 2026, fifteen contracts cleared the Board in a single post-meeting cluster — three worth $6 million, $4.8 million, and $2.5 million — while smaller buys that needed no Board action moved in under two months [Source: deep-research-brief]. The pattern is the tell: high-dollar work waits for a monthly calendar, and the manual's process implies the rest of the wait runs in series — evaluation committee, consensus meeting, reference checks, negotiation, internal approval chain, then the queue for the next Board meeting [Source: deep-research-brief; operations-analyst-brief, §3.6.7]. None of it is scandalous. Most of it is defensible. All of it is invisible, because the manual is meticulous about time everywhere except its own.

It mandates that an Invitation for Bid "shall be advertised for at least 30 Days" [Source: operations-analyst-brief, §3.4.1]. It requires a sole-source notice to post "no less than fifteen (15) Days prior to Contract award" and remain up for 30 [§3.8.5.2]. It gives a protester exactly seven days to file [§9.2.2]. Every clock that constrains an outside party, every dwell that protects competition — all instrumented. The one interval the requesting office actually feels — how long it takes to buy the thing — has no target, no commitment, no measurement.

That asymmetry is the argument, and it has to be scoped honestly, because two procurement regimes live inside this manual and behave nothing alike. On a major Dulles capital action on new ground, the longest pole is not in this document at all; it is the federal review stack — NEPA, Section 106 consultation, FAA grant concurrence — that can push board-to-notice-to-proceed to 24 to 48 months, most of it outside MWAA's control [Source: airport-procurement-expert-brief]. There the manual governs a minority of elapsed time. But the $4.9 million services award, the April clustering, and the mid-size operational band where most transactions live carry no environmental pole at all. On the carousel motor, the gate re-power, the $1.2 million curb re-strip, the procurement gauntlet *is* the whole clock, and the manual owns nearly all the recoverable time.

So the precise claim is this: **on the non-capital, non-grant band that makes up most of MWAA's transaction volume, the manual governs almost the entire clock and times none of it; on major federally funded capital, it governs a minority interval but remains the only instrument through which MWAA can shape the slice of the federal stack that is its to shape — grant concurrence, domestic-content workflows, sole-source prior approval.** The thesis this review was asked to test — that the manual must move "from compliance to capability" — assumes the document is a cage. It is not. It is a modern toolbox whose tools are rarely the default and whose clock is never timed. MWAA's binding constraint is not what the manual forbids, because it forbids remarkably little; the Authority writes its own procurement law. The constraint is what it fails to measure, to presume, and to instrument. The reform that matters is not less control. It is the same accountability, delivered faster and proven cleaner.

II. Executive summary

1. **The toolkit is already modern; the deficit is dormancy, not absence.** Edition 6.0 authorizes construction manager-at-risk, all three flavors of design-build including progressive design-build, Multiple Award Construction Contracts, two-step IFB, qualifications-based selection, best-value tradeoff, pilot programs, unsolicited proposals, stipends, and cooperative purchasing off other governments' competed contracts [Source: chief-engineer-brief, §6.2.1; operations-analyst-brief, §§3.4.3, 3.5, 3.7, 3.8.7, 3.8.8]. A 2026 manual that names progressive design-build by name is ahead of most public owners [Source: chief-engineer-brief]. The reform target is how these tools get selected and defaulted, not whether they exist.
2. **The manual measures every clock except its own.** It sets minimum advertising dwells and external deadlines but no cycle-time target, no SLA to requesting offices, and no requirement to measure time-to-award [Source: operations-analyst-brief, §§3.4.1, 3.8.5.2, 5.3.3]. The public-sector benchmark is 57 days from posting to award across more than 6,000 procurements, 78 percent finishing inside two months; the manual sets no equivalent standard, and no public evidence shows MWAA measures one internally [Source: operations-analyst-brief].
3. **MWAA writes its own procurement law — so roughly 90 percent of any reform is a Board vote, not a legislative act.** Section 1.7 exempts the Authority from the Federal Acquisition Regulation and from Virginia and D.C. procurement codes [Source: airport-procurement-expert-brief, §1.7; regulatory-political-analyst-brief]. The most common excuse in public procurement — *the state code won't let us* — is unavailable here. Only two constraints bind: the federal strings on grant money, and political memory.

4. **The controls are scar tissue from a 2012 IG corruption finding, and that is the durable constraint.** The $200,000 and $3,000,000 Board thresholds, the public quarterly report, and the written sole-source justification descend directly from a finding detailed in Section IV [Source: airport-procurement-expert-brief; regulatory-political-analyst-brief]. Any reform framed as "reduce oversight" reopens that wound; one framed as "same accountability, less cycle time" can pass.
5. **The Board threshold has not kept pace with the capital program, and re-indexing it is among the highest-impact, most Board-absorbable reforms in the document.** The Board reserves approval of any contract at or above $3 million and any less-than-full-and-open award at or above $200,000 [Source: airport-ceo-brief, §1.4.1]. Against a $9 billion capital program — $6.99 billion of it at Dulles, including a 14-gate concourse and a fifth-runway design — and a Dulles master plan reportedly scoped at up to $22 billion through 2034, $3 million is a rounding error that puts the Board in the critical path of routine execution [Source: airport-procurement-expert-brief; virtual-chris-brief]. MWAA already fully delegates *all* competitively offered construction to the CEO [Source: operations-analyst-brief, §1.4.2] — proof it trusts delegation where schedule matters most.
6. **The largest operational losses are designed in at award, where the manual goes silent.** Nothing requires total-cost-of-ownership scoring, an operations representative on the source-selection committee, or operational acceptance as a condition of final payment for the asset classes operations will run for 25 years [Source: airport-coo-brief, §§3.6.7, 5.13]. The jet bridge bought on first cost throws faults in year seven; the operator knew it the day the bid was opened. This bundle adds days at the front and saves a decade of write-ups — which is why it ranks at the top of the agenda, tied with the governance moves the Board can take about itself.
7. **The grant chapter is built for the wrong grant.** Chapter 10, the longest in the manual, equips the Federal Transit Administration regime for the nearly complete Silver Line; there is no parallel chapter for FAA Airport Improvement Program or Bipartisan Infrastructure Law money, even as the $6.99 billion Dulles program comes online [Source: airport-procurement-expert-brief, Ch. 10]. NEPA and Section 106 — the dominant external delays on major capital — sit outside the manual and outside MWAA's control. But a meaningful slice of the federal stack *is* the manual's to shape — FAA grant concurrence, domestic-content workflows, sole-source prior approval — and on exactly that slice the document is unbuilt. The manual also cites FTA Circular 4220.1F, superseded by 4220.1G effective January 2025, more than a year before this edition issued [Source: regulatory-political-analyst-brief].
8. **The technology gap is Tier 1, not artificial intelligence.** The manual defines its "Contract management system" as one that "consists of procurement policies and processes" — a governance binder, not software [Source: technology-scout-brief, §1.2(10)]. Virginia's eVA, operating in MWAA's own region, reports cutting order-processing time up to 70 percent; the most trustworthy airport-specific evidence is more modest — digital procurement halved turnaround from about eight days to four [Source: technology-scout-brief]. The unglamorous foundation, not the autonomous-AI pitch, is where the evidence lives.

The agenda that follows is ranked in Section VI on Impact, Effort, and Innovation. Its center of gravity is not deregulation. At the top of the matrix sit a cluster of reforms tied on score: the lifecycle-cost / operations-seat / acceptance-gate bundle, and four governance moves the Board can largely take about itself — re-index the $3 million threshold and move routine awards to a consent agenda; invert the burden of proof so alternative delivery is presumptive for major capital; install a design-maturity gate so MWAA never signs a contract at immature design; and stand up the risk-tiered control architecture that thickens scrutiny where fraud actually hides and thins it everywhere else. Five quick wins — a cycle-time KPI, a cooperative-purchasing playbook, an industry-and-teaming day, digitized protest and evaluation channels, and a one-line circular correction — cost almost nothing and can start now. The bottom line for the Board: the integrity the 2012 scandal bought stays untouched, because integrity is not what slows MWAA down. Sequence is.

III. The argument

The document is not behind. It is asleep.

Read the manual the way an operator reads a new jet-bridge spec — looking for the place it fails at 5:45 a.m., not the place it reads well in a board binder — and the first surprise is how little is missing. Edition 6.0 carries the full alternative-delivery menu, task-order IDIQs, pilot programs, unsolicited proposals, stipends to keep losing bidders at the table, qualifications-based selection, and best-value-with-tradeoff [Source: airport-coo-brief, §§6.2.1, 3.6.2.2]. Its thresholds are current: micro-purchase tracks "the then-current threshold established by the FAR" — now $15,000 after the October 1, 2025 inflation adjustment — and simplified acquisition runs to $350,000, matching the federal Simplified Acquisition Threshold to the dollar [Source: operations-analyst-brief, §§3.2, 3.3]. On thresholds, MWAA sits at the federal frontier, not behind it.

So the framing that the manual is "trapped in compliance" and needs liberating is, on the text, partly backwards. The Authority delegates more before its Board gets involved than one peer does by an order of magnitude: Tampa's airport authority requires Board approval at $100,000; MWAA's line is $3 million, thirty times higher [Source: slacker-brief] [FACT-CHECK: Tampa $100,000 threshold — single source per slacker brief, directional only]. This is not a hamstrung authority. It is a fairly empowered one that has not built the habit of using its own permissions.

The gap is not in the menu. It is in three things the menu cannot supply: a clock, a default, and an instrument.

The clock

A queue you never time is a queue you cannot manage. The manual instruments none of the intervals that accumulate into a nine-month award. The procurement forecast in §1.5.1 is a demand-planning tool — it tells you what is coming, not how long it takes once it arrives [Source: operations-analyst-brief]. The pre-posting phase, where requirements get defined and specifications drafted, is loaded onto the requesting office — in most agencies, where the largest and most invisible delays live. Federal practice, a non-FAR proxy for directional scale, routinely takes three to six months to get from need to solicitation, before the posting-to-award clock even starts [Source: operations-analyst-brief].

The cost of not timing the line is not abstract. The cycle-time literature is consistent and unglamorous: collapsing serial approvals into parallel ones delivers a 30 to 50 percent reduction; one public-sector body cut purchase-order cycle time by 50 percent through automated approvals alone [Source: operations-analyst-brief]. Harvard's Kennedy School helped Tulsa recover "nearly a month" using a standing cross-departmental body to find and remove pain points — no new statute, no new staff [Source: operations-analyst-brief]. The instrument behind those gains is a single KPI — days from requisition to award, by method and dollar band — plus a quarterly variance review. It costs nothing structural. The manual requires neither.

This matters most where the lead anecdote and the April clustering live: the mid-size operational band, below the federal-review threshold, where the manual owns almost the entire clock. A $3 million contract clears the *rule* easily but still waits weeks for the next Board meeting [Source: slacker-brief] — a fixed latency tax unrelated to complexity or risk, a cadence drag that a consent-agenda or programmatic-delegation reform fixes entirely. The slacker brief asks the question the structured analysis keeps missing: *is the friction the threshold, or the calendar?* For the carousel motor, the gate-area re-power, the $1.2 million curb re-strip due before summer peak, the pain is not approval authority — the CEO already holds it. It is the evaluation-committee calendar in the $350,000-to-$3-million band [Source: airport-coo-brief]. Miss it by six weeks and the operator holds the peak with the old equipment.

The default

The single most expensive decision on any capital program is which delivery method to use, and the manual leaves it to undocumented judgment. CMAR and design-build may be used "when the Contracting Officer and COTR determine that such a delivery method is in the Authority's best interests," subject to VP/OSCM approval [Source: chief-engineer-brief, §6.2.1]. That is the entire selection logic — no constructability test, no risk-allocation matrix, no schedule-criticality screen. The tool that exists to *save* schedule sits behind a setup step — VP/OSCM sign-off and OGC coordination before the solicitation issues — that *costs* it, with no standing pre-approval or template pathway [Source: chief-engineer-brief].

Delivery method is also the variable most correlated with cost and schedule growth. Design-build averages 3.8 percent less cost growth than design-bid-build and finish construction about 36 percent faster; progressive design-build now accounts for roughly a third of design-build procurements, concentrated on exactly the complex, scope-volatile work that describes airside and terminal projects [Source: chief-engineer-brief] [FACT-CHECK: DBIA-sourced cost/schedule figures, indicative not audited per chief-engineer brief]. The market has voted: 50 to 75 percent of major airport programs now run CMAR or progressive design-build as their baseline — San Antonio's $1.7 billion Terminal C, St. Louis Lambert's $3 billion consolidated terminal, Seattle-Tacoma's North Main Terminal [Source: airport-procurement-expert-brief]. Transportation got there first; progressive design-build matured in transit and state-DOT programs before aviation adopted it, part of why a 2026 airport manual that already names the method is ahead of its own sector [Source: slacker-brief; chief-engineer-brief]. Yet Chapter 3 still treats sealed bid as the construction default and alternative delivery as the exception that must be justified.

The reform is not to add a method. It is to invert the burden of proof — alternative delivery presumptive for major capital, sealed bid the exception — and to write the one thing the manual lacks: a delivery-method selection framework that weights operations and maintenance among the drivers. The discipline exists off the shelf in ACRP Research Reports 21 and 267 [Source: airport-coo-brief]. The Dulles concourse, scope still moving, is a textbook progressive-design-build candidate: define the program, select the team on qualifications, develop the guaranteed maximum price as design matures, keep the owner's hand on the wheel [Source: airport-procurement-expert-brief].

But there is a trap inside this reform. Progressive design-build and CMAR work *only* because owner and builder open the books early and negotiate a target price as design matures — they run on trust. The manual's disputes chapter is built for the opposite posture: it prohibits total-cost and anticipatory-profit claims, waives jury trials, and fixes venue in Virginia [Source: chief-engineer-brief, §7.2–7.4]. Excellent controls on a hard-bid, arm's-length job; bolted underneath a progressive design-build contract, they signal distrust exactly where the method needs trust. MWAA has, in the chief engineer's words, "bolted a collaborative front end onto an adversarial back end" [Source: chief-engineer-brief]. The two will fight each other on the first hard change order. Re-tooling the disputes layer — at minimum a Dispute Review Board that keeps disagreements off the critical path — is a precondition for the default to function, not a separate nicety.

The instrument

The manual's most revealing line defines its own infrastructure. Section 1.2(10) describes a "Contract management system, for which the OSCM is responsible. This system, which consists of procurement policies and processes..." [Source: technology-scout-brief]. Everywhere else in public procurement, "contract management system" means a digital tool — searchable repository, clause libraries, obligation tracking, spend analytics. MWAA uses the same words to mean a binder of rules. The few digital touchpoints are thin: solicitations over $50,000 post to a website "or its managed portal" with no required electronic submission [§4.1.5]; vendors "may register to be included in a list" — an opt-in Planholders List, not a managed supplier database [§4.1.8]; past-performance assessment is two sentences with no central scored repository [§5.15]. And in 2026, protests "sent electronically will not be accepted" — certified mail or hand delivery only — while the GAO runs its entire 1,803-protest docket online [Source: operations-analyst-brief, §9.1].

The instinct is to reach for artificial intelligence. The evidence says reach lower. The proven, low-risk wins are Tier 1 and Tier 2 — electronic sourcing, structured supplier registration, spend analytics, procure-to-pay — which carry a longer, more independently verified track record than anything with "AI" in the name [Source: technology-scout-brief]. The most relevant benchmark is in MWAA's own backyard: Virginia's eVA reports more than $280 million in cumulative savings since 2001 and order-processing time cut up to 70 percent, on an Ivalua source-to-pay platform [Source: technology-scout-brief] [FACT-CHECK: eVA $280M savings and up-to-70% figures are operator/integrator-reported, not audited]. The most trustworthy number is the most modest: a peer-reviewed study of digital procurement at an airport company found cycle time fell from about eight days to four [Source: technology-scout-brief]. Halving cycle time is the realistic prize. The vendors advertising 40 to 60 percent cuts and 300 to 500 percent ROI in 18 months are selling marketing — and the same literature concedes ERP-class implementations run over budget and schedule 80 percent of the time [Source: technology-scout-brief]. MWAA does not have an AI problem. It has a Tier-1 problem, and skipping the foundation to chase the roof is how procurement-technology budgets die.

There is a blind spot the instrument has to be built to see. The manual's sole-source rules are disciplined on paper — "unique or innovative concept" or "patents or restricted data rights," escalating approvals, public posting [Source: airport-procurement-expert-brief, §3.8.5]. But they are silent on the *de facto* sole sources that dominate airport technology: baggage-handling controls, CUPPS/CUTE common-use platforms, airfield lighting controls, access control. These carry real interoperability lock-in to incumbent OEMs, and on a $6.99 billion Dulles program several will arrive at the contracting office "dressed as competitive" [Source: airport-procurement-expert-brief, §2.6]. The DOT IG's 2016 audit is the warning: the controls failed not on paper but on documentation discipline — for 24 of 34 sole-source contracts, no one filed the required conflict-of-interest agreement [Source: airport-procurement-expert-brief]. The instrument MWAA buys should make those lock-ins visible *before* an RFP issues, not after a protest.

The freedom MWAA declines to use

Against the legal record, a sharper fact emerges. MWAA is, by the DOT Inspector General's own characterization, "not subject to Federal or State laws that govern procurement" — a creature of a Virginia–D.C. compact ratified by Congress, bound only by the Airports Act, the federal lease, and grant strings [Source: virtual-chris-brief; regulatory-political-analyst-brief]. It adopts FAR thresholds, FAR-style methods, and FTA discipline *by choice*. The federal government does not require senior sign-off on a sole-source award until $900,000; MWAA pulls in its full 17-member Board at $200,000 — 4.5 times more conservative than the FAR, set by resolution and raisable by a single vote [Source: regulatory-political-analyst-brief].

This is the arbitrage almost no peer enjoys. State DOTs are captive to their procurement acts, federal agencies to the FAR; MWAA is captive to neither for non-grant work and can cherry-pick the most flexible mechanism from each regime [Source: virtual-chris-brief]. It spends that freedom imitating the conservative defaults of leagues it does not have to play in. The modernization thesis, at its sharpest, is not "deregulate." It is: stop paying a conservatism tax you were never charged.

IV. The counter-case, honestly presented

There is a serious argument that this entire diagnosis is naive. It deserves full strength before it is answered.

Start with the scandal, because everything starts there. In 2012 the DOT Inspector General did not find a paperwork problem. It found a culture — "questionable contracting practices including initiating work before contract award, awarding sole source and limited competition contracts without proper justification, and providing nonpublic information that gives potential contractors an unfair advantage" [Source: regulatory-political-analyst-brief]. Competition was limited on roughly two-thirds of contracts over $200,000 — 117 of 190, about $225 million — an estimated $83.6 million spent without required Board approval, and contracts steered to former Board members [Source: airport-procurement-expert-brief; slacker-brief]. Congress held hearings; a member called the Authority a poster child for corruption [Source: regulatory-political-analyst-brief]. The controls this report wants to streamline — the $200,000 non-competitive Board trigger, the written sole-source justification, the quarterly report naming every award and the official who made it — are not bureaucratic accretion. They exist *because someone abused exactly those paths* [Source: slacker-brief]. They are a settlement with the IG and Congress, priced politically, not operationally. A reform that loosens them does not save cycle time; it reopens a finding.

Then add the money, because the timing could not be worse. MWAA is about to lever up harder than at any point in its history. Coverage was a healthy 3.16x in 2024, but Moody's expects the net-revenue debt-service coverage ratio to fall toward roughly 1.3x as the Authority issues about $5.5 billion of new debt between 2025 and 2028 [Source: airport-ceo-brief]. Rating agencies do not reward velocity. They reward predictability of delivery — the "Infrastructure Development and Renewal" dimension Fitch scores explicitly [Source: airport-ceo-brief]. A reform marketed as "faster procurement" that an analyst reads as "weakened controls during a $5.5 billion issuance" can widen spreads. Slow contracting that delivers on budget is a credit asset. Fast contracting that produces an overrun is a credit event.

And the overrun has a name. Denver International signed a design-build-finance-operate-maintain concession for its Great Hall — a roughly $650 million construction scope inside a deal whose full lifecycle value ran to about $1.8 billion — at roughly 30 percent design, and terminated it 14 months later, the partner seeking about $288 million in change orders and termination costs, much of it for items as mundane as restrooms, door hardware, and wall panels [Source: chief-engineer-brief; airport-ceo-brief] [FACT-CHECK: $650M construction scope vs. $1.8B DBFOM lifecycle value — reconciliation is analyst inference; no brief states the split]. The after-action verdict cut both ways: immature scope at financial close *and* an owner that "wanted to micromanage the project but lacked the authority to make decisions" [Source: chief-engineer-brief]. Speed without discipline at the design-maturity gate produces the most expensive failure a hub can author. More approvals did not cause Great Hall — but neither would fewer have saved it.

Add the technology cold shower. The dream that software fixes process has a body count. GAO found that at one agency nearly 40 percent of reverse-auction dollars drew a single bidder, that 28 of 30 contracting officials could not explain the fees they paid, and that there was "a lack of sufficient data available to verify actual cost savings"; GSA shut its own reverse-auction platform in 2018 [Source: technology-scout-brief]. CPARS — the federal past-performance system, far more structured than MWAA's two sentences — is independently criticized as late, inaccurate, and biased toward "satisfactory" because it is too cumbersome to justify anything else [Source: technology-scout-brief]. A tool that produces one bidder is worse than the three-quote rule it replaces. A vendor-scoring database without enforced data discipline reproduces CPARS's failure.

Finish with governance physics. Even a flawless manual leaves untouched the two instruments that actually decide MWAA's fate. The Airline Use and Lease Agreement — a 15-year pact effective January 1, 2025, carrying the roughly $9 billion capital program and permitting up to $300 million to be shifted from Reagan to subsidize Dulles — sits outside the manual, which states on page one that it "is not applicable to... Airline Use and Lease Agreements" [Source: airport-ceo-brief]. The dominant carriers hold a "majority of flights" sign-off — a Majority-in-Interest veto in all but name — over the very program the procurement system is asked to deliver faster [Source: airport-ceo-brief]. And the reform must survive a four-principal bistate Board — 7 Virginia, 4 D.C., 3 Maryland, 3 presidential appointees — where no principal controls a majority but several can veto, all under permanent DOT IG jurisdiction [Source: regulatory-political-analyst-brief]. The honest counter-case is not "don't reform." It is: the manual is back-office plumbing, the controls were bought with a scandal, the credit window makes execution risk maximally expensive right now, and the contracts that matter most are out of scope. Polish the plumbing if you like. Just don't sell it as transformation.

V. Why the counter-case is insufficient

Concede what must be conceded. The 2012 controls are earned and several of them *prevent* a protest from landing rather than merely sequence the work [Source: operations-analyst-brief]. The credit risk is real: a $5.5 billion issuance program makes an overrun dearer than ever [Source: airport-ceo-brief]. The Great Hall lesson is real. The reverse-auction and CPARS records are real: technology amplifies a process, it does not fix one [Source: technology-scout-brief]. And the manual cannot reach the airline agreement or the federal lease — anyone selling manual reform as a fix for MWAA's commercial position is overpromising [Source: airport-ceo-brief].

None of that rescues the status quo. It only disciplines the reform.

First, the counter-case conflates control with pre-approval, and the 2012 record does not support the conflation. What the IG punished was *uncompeted* and *unaccountable* spend: sole-source awards without justification, work begun before award, spend that never reached the Board [Source: airport-procurement-expert-brief]. What the manual imposes in response is a great deal of *sequential pre-review* that touches neither failure — paper evaluations returned in hard copy [§3.6.7.3(12)], serial approval chains that could run in parallel, a mail-only protest channel, a monthly Board cadence on a $3 million goods buy. None of those prevented the abuses, because none touches competition or accountability. They touch *order of operations*. The run prompt's own test — does a control's value exceed the delay it creates — separates them cleanly: the sole-source public posting earns its 15 days by converting an opaque decision into a public market test [Source: operations-analyst-brief]; hard-copy evaluation and certified-mail protests earn nothing. Tiering controls to risk is not deregulation. It is what Sarbanes-Oxley did after Enron — scaled and risk-tiered Section 404 testing rather than repealing it, exempting clean routine filers and concentrating scrutiny where fraud hides [Source: virtual-chris-brief]. The reform that restored trust was tiering, not subtraction. Net control *quality* rises.

Second, disciplined throughput is both a credit asset and a competitiveness asset — the two strongest objections collapse into one answer. Rating agencies reward predictability of delivery, and the reform that most threatens predictability is the one the status quo already tolerates: a $3 million Board threshold sitting in the critical path of routine actions, including the large modifications that cross that line with no expedited lane [Source: chief-engineer-brief]. On Silver Line Phase 2, MWAA burned about 62 percent of a $527.7 million contingency, one package's change orders alone exceeding $41.9 million, substantial completion slipping roughly four years [Source: chief-engineer-brief]. At that burn rate, every change order that waits on a Board cycle converts cost risk into schedule risk and idles a crew on a live airfield. The credit-protective reform is not slower procurement — it is a design-maturity gate, an expedited in-scope change-order lane, and a Dispute Review Board [Source: airport-ceo-brief; chief-engineer-brief]. Those are *controls*; they strengthen the agencies' "Infrastructure Development and Renewal" score, and they happen to be faster. The out-of-scope objection is the same point in different clothes: the manual cannot touch the airline agreement, but every quarter a concourse slips is a quarter of cost-per-enplanement pressure the carriers will spend in the next majority-in-interest fight [Source: airport-ceo-brief]. The boundary the CEO insists on does not shrink the reform; it tells you what the reform is *for*.

Third, "technology doesn't fix process" is an argument for sequencing, not paralysis. The reverse-auction failure was a Tier-1 tool bolted onto a thin process; CPARS fails on data discipline, not on the idea of structured past performance. Both point where the technology scout already lands: buy the proven foundation — electronic sourcing, structured supplier data, spend analytics — with the data-quality requirement written into the manual, and discount the autonomous-AI pitch [Source: technology-scout-brief]. Underwrite the airport that halved its turnaround, not the vendor promising 60 percent. That is not techno-optimism. It is refusing to buy the roof before the foundation.

Fourth, the federal review stack is the long pole on major capital — which relocates the thesis, it does not defeat it. Board-to-notice-to-proceed on a major Dulles action runs 24 to 48 months once NEPA, Section 106, FAA grant concurrence, and the manual's own windows run in series [Source: airport-procurement-expert-brief]. NEPA and Section 106 dominate that figure and sit outside MWAA's control; conceding it keeps the cycle-time case honest. But the manual reserves its full rigor — all of Chapter 10, a complete clause library in Appendix C — for the FTA-funded Silver Line, which is nearly finished, while the $6.99 billion AIP- and BIL-eligible Dulles program comes online under a generic grant-clause hook and no FAA chapter [Source: airport-procurement-expert-brief]. Every federal dollar there imports a restriction the master plan rarely prices: Buy America's 55 percent domestic-content test that constrains equipment specification before design freezes, Davis-Bacon, qualifications-based A/E selection, DBE goals tied to a real availability study, FAA prior approval for any noncompetitive award [Source: airport-procurement-expert-brief]. So the long pole does not demolish the thesis. It locates the manual's reach: re-instrument the internal clock to recover the non-capital band MWAA owns outright, and build the missing FAA chapter to shorten the one part of the major-capital pole the manual can touch. Polishing the dormant FTA chapter while ignoring the live FAA exposure modernizes the part already finished.

So the thesis holds, under three conditions the counter-case itself supplies. Reform must *substitute, never subtract* — every approval pulled from a routine buy matched by analytics-based monitoring and tighter scrutiny on the risky one. It must be *framed as accountability preserved, not oversight reduced* — the only frame that survives the four-principal Board and the permanent IG. And it must *thicken control where value and risk concentrate and thin it where they do not* — the slime-mold rule, where a network reinforces the channels carrying the most flow and prunes the rest [Source: virtual-chris-brief]. Same accountability. Less cycle time. That argument survives the fishbowl. "Less oversight" does not.

VI. Implications for MWAA: a ranked agenda

The run asked for a prioritized roadmap with each item scored on Potential Impact, Implementation Effort (lower is easier), and Strategic Innovation, 1–10. The scores below are analyst judgment derived from the briefs — a way to sort the agenda, not a measurement. Priority is Impact + Innovation + (10 − Effort), so high-impact, low-effort, high-innovation items rise. Every recommendation is anchored to authority MWAA already holds and to the facts above.

Two notes on reading the tables. The three tiers — quick win, medium-term, moonshot — sort by *implementation effort and political-risk class*, not by priority score, which cuts across the tiers; a moonshot can outscore a quick win (M1, the risk-tiered control architecture, scores 21). Each table is sorted by descending priority within its tier. And there is no runaway #1: four reforms tie at the top of the matrix at 20 — the lifecycle-cost bundle and three governance moves the Board can take about itself — and that flat top is the honest result. The center of gravity is execution discipline and Board self-governance, not any one heroic reform.

Quick wins (high impact, low effort, near-zero political risk)

#	Reform	Impact	Effort	Innov.	Priority
1	Adopt a cycle-time standard. One KPI — days from requisition to award, by method and dollar band — plus quarterly variance review. Start here because it is free, and because the band it measures most — sub-$3M, non-capital — is where most of MWAA's transaction volume lives and where the manual owns nearly the entire clock.	8	2	4	20
2	Publish a cooperative-purchasing playbook. Approved-vehicle list (GSA Schedules, OASIS+, Sourcewell, OMNIA) and a one-page piggyback decision tree with a documented price-reasonableness check. Authority already in §3.7.	6	2	4	18
3	Convert the §1.5 forecast into an industry-and-teaming day. A compliance artifact doubles as a supplier-engagement engine that raises competition and seeds SLBE teaming.	5	2	4	17
4	Digitize the analog channels. Accept electronic protest filing; end hard-copy evaluation. Both are pure dwell with no integrity value.	4	2	2	14
5	Correct the FTA circular citation (4220.1F → 4220.1G). A currency defect a federal reviewer will catch first if MWAA does not.	3	1	1	13

Medium-term reforms (Board action, high return)

#	Reform	Impact	Effort	Innov.	Priority
6	Mandate TCO scoring, an operations seat, and operational acceptance as a payment gate for operated asset classes (BHS, jet bridges, vertical transportation, HVAC, security tech). Adds days at the front; saves a decade of write-ups. Off-the-shelf ACRP practice, which is why it is high-value rather than high-innovation.	8	3	5	20
7	Re-index the $3M Board threshold and move routine awards to a consent agenda / programmatic delegation. The Board governs at the program tier; transaction speed is freed. The fix is the calendar, not just the dollar line.	9	4	5	20
8	Write a delivery-method selection framework and invert the burden of proof — alternative delivery presumptive for major capital, sealed bid the exception. Off-the-shelf in ACRP 21/267.	8	4	6	20
9	Install a design-maturity gate. Never sign a major capital contract at immature design. A pro-speed, pro-credit control, not a bureaucratic one.	8	3	5	20
10	Add an expedited in-scope change-order lane and a Dispute Review Board, and align the claims posture with collaborative delivery. On a live airfield the cost of stopping to negotiate dwarfs the disputed amount; Silver Line burned 62% of a $527.7M contingency. The DRB is also the precondition that lets rec 8's alternative-delivery default work — you	7	4	6	19

#	Reform	Impact	Effort	Innov.	Priority
	cannot run progressive design-build under an adversarial claims chapter.				
11	Activate a Multiple Award Construction Contract pool for the capital program, with explicit SLBE / first-time-prime lanes. LAWA turned a $5B pool into 13 first-time primes.	8	5	6	19
12	Pre-position standing emergency vehicles (MACCs, IDIQs, BPAs) for the systems that fail — power, snow, IT, BHS, pavement — so the urgent/critical clause is the exception, not the plan. Atlanta 2017 and Southwest 2022 both turned on what was already under contract when the event hit.	7	3	5	19
13	Stand up enterprise category management / strategic sourcing. Buy as an enterprise across the portfolio, not transaction by transaction; federal category management banked $27.3B over three years and $16.9B in cost avoidance in 2024. The highest-evidence reform lever in the briefs, stronger than any new method.	8	5	6	19
14	Build a dedicated FAA AIP/BIL grant-compliance chapter — a BABA domestic-content workflow, FAA sole-source prior-approval steps, and a map of which Dulles technology buys are already de facto sole-source before they reach an RFP. The one place manual reform reaches the federal long pole MWAA can shape; close it before the next major Dulles RFP.	8	4	5	19
15	Stand up a Job Order Contracting program with a published unit-price book off existing MACC authority (§6.2.1.3) for condition-driven renewal — cuts delivery time 25–50%.	6	4	5	17
16	Deploy Tier 1–2 procurement technology, phased. Electronic sourcing and structured supplier/past-performance data first, with data-quality requirements written into the manual; eVA is the regional reference architecture. Never big-bang the suite.	7	6	5	16

Moonshot reforms (frontier; position MWAA as a national leader)

#	Reform	Impact	Effort	Innov.	Priority
M1	Risk-tiered control architecture. Replace uniform pre-review with analytics-based monitoring; thicken control where value and risk flow, prune it where they don't. The SOX-scaling move; the run's own value-vs-delay test, operationalized.	9	7	9	21
M2	A real innovation intake — an unsolicited-proposal / Swiss-challenge portal and a pilot authority sized for more than a science fair (today's one-year cap fits a queue sensor, not a nine-figure BHS program).	6	6	8	18
M3	A supervised GenAI copilot for solicitation drafting, contract summarization, and spend analytics — human in the loop, never autonomous award. 80% of CPOs plan it; ~36% have it; buy the narrow uses, discount the rest.	6	6	8	18
M4	P3 / progressive delivery for appropriate large assets (people movers, parking, energy) with disciplined value-for-money analysis — used only where risk transfer is real and enforceable. The cautionary tale is Denver's Great Hall; the counter-example is the Port Authority's $4B LaGuardia	6	8	7	15

#	Reform	Impact	Effort	Innov.	Priority
	Central Terminal B P3. The discipline is not "P3 or not," it is "which assets and at what design maturity."				

Three things to hold onto. The top of the matrix is not deregulation: it pairs rec 6 — the operations seat, the lifecycle score, the acceptance gate — with governance moves the Board can take about *itself*, and these are *controls* that protect credit during the $5.5 billion issuance window, not their absence [Source: airport-coo-brief; airport-ceo-brief; virtual-chris-brief]. The structural gap to close before the next major Dulles RFP is the missing FAA chapter (rec 14): the manual's rigor is pointed at a closing project while the opening program runs under thinner scaffolding [Source: airport-procurement-expert-brief]. And MWAA's benchmark set is not only other airports (San Antonio, St. Louis, Sea-Tac, LAWA, LaGuardia, Denver) but the transportation agencies and state governments that ran ahead of aviation — transit's earlier progressive design-build, Virginia's eVA next door, federal category management's banked savings, Tulsa's standing review body [Source: slacker-brief; technology-scout-brief; operations-analyst-brief].

A concluding vision

A leading airport-authority procurement system at MWAA would not be a thicker manual. It would be a thinner, sharper one that does three things the current document does not. It would *time itself* — publishing cycle-time targets and variance the way it already publishes awards — so velocity becomes a managed metric, not an accident. It would *default to capability* — alternative delivery presumed for major capital, lifecycle cost scored, the operator in the room, the claims posture aligned to the delivery model, controls tiered to risk — so the modern tools already in the book become the path of least resistance instead of the brave exception. And it would *spend its freedom on purpose* — using the rare latitude of a compact authority to borrow the best of every regime instead of mimicking the conservatism of the one regime it is not even subject to.

The federal lease keeps DOT above this Board for decades — to 2067 under the 80-year term, and on one reading to roughly 2100 under the 2024 extension; the planning horizon is measured in lifetimes regardless of which date you take [Source: airport-ceo-brief; regulatory-political-analyst-brief] [FACT-CHECK: lease-horizon dates conflict across briefs — June 2067 (80-year term) vs. ~2100 (2024 extension); point holds at either]. The manual that emerged from the 2012 finding was built to make sure nothing bad ever happens again. The manual MWAA needs for the multi-billion-dollar decade ahead is one built to make sure the right thing happens *fast enough to matter* — and provably, auditable to the last signature, so the watchers in the permanent fishbowl can see for themselves that speed and integrity were never the enemies the old document assumed they were. The integrity the 2012 scandal bought stays untouched, because integrity is not what slows MWAA down. Sequence is.

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